Rethinking the Publishing System: A Proposal for the Evaluation and Editing of Digital Academic Objects

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Since their creation, digital humanities (DH) have introduced new forms of publication, methodologies, and ways of communicating research. Efforts to recognize the field and its wide range of outputs have been translated into guides for evaluating careers (Clement, 2019) and the assessment of various digital resources (Galina, 2022; Odell & Pollock, 2016; Risam, 2014). However, the research outputs of DH have not yet been fully integrated into the formal academic communication system.[1] While there are efforts in this direction (Helling, 2024), and some journals already accept and publish various types of data and multimedia results, their full integration into universities, particularly in publishing departments, has not yet been achieved. Thus, within the context of open science and with full awareness of the epistemological value that the wide production of DH contributes to knowledge construction, this presentation aims to contribute to this debate by proposing a series of guidelines for the evaluation and editing of these objects.

The digitization of academic communication has profoundly transformed research practices in the humanities. In this context, digital academic objects have emerged not only as an extension of traditional publications but as new ways to represent and share knowledge. These objects include databases, repositories, critical editions, visualizations, scripts, and other artifacts, enabling new and complex ways of presenting research findings. However, this shift calls for a reconfiguration of evaluation and editing processes to ensure that these objects are not only academically rigorous but also accessible and reusable within the digital open science ecosystem. A key aspect of this proposal is the epistemological value of digital objects. As Priani (2020) notes, data are constructed within an epistemological context. Digital objects, being based on computational data, not only allow for storage and retrieval of information but also constitute objects of knowledge in themselves. As Drucker (2010) states, the digitization of data not only allows for storage but also creates new forms of analysis that expand interpretative possibilities within the humanities.

This proposal builds on Bhaskar's (2014) publishing theory, incorporating the evaluation and editing of digital objects within his concepts of frames/models and filtering/ amplification. Evaluation must combine academic rigor with technical analysis. From an academic perspective, the evaluation must ensure that the digital object meets the highest standards of intellectual rigor, considering the clarity, depth, and relevance of the content within the context of the discipline. Additionally, the evaluation should address aspects such as the interoperability of data, the structure of the object, and its reusability within other research frameworks. To ensure that digital objects can be widely used and shared, it is crucial to apply the FAIR principles, which make objects easily locatable, accessible, and adaptable for future research.

The proposed model emphasizes collaboration throughout the evaluation and editing processes. This process should not be seen as a series of isolated steps but as a joint effort among authors, reviewers, editors, and a wide range of technicians, who collaborate to ensure that the object not only meets academic standards but is also accessible, understandable, and useful to the broader academic community. Interdisciplinary and multidisciplinary collaboration in the evaluation and editing stages is essential to ensure that the digital object is valuable not only from an academic perspective but also from a technical one.

The editing process ensures academic rigor and technical precision, using standards like Dublin Core, TEI, and protocols like OAI-PMH. It includes the creation of detailed metadata, usage licenses, and methodological notes, which collectively serve as a digital paratext, drawing on Genette's (2001) theory of paratext. This paratext provides proper context for the objects and enables their effective use within the academic community. As Bhaskar emphasizes, the frames (or structures) in the digital object not only allow for its correct presentation but also amplify its academic and interpretative potential. The process emphasizes acknowledging contributors—researchers, editors, programmers, and designers—by linking them to recognized identifiers, strengthening the ecosystem and ensuring clear attribution. Furthermore, the inclusion of abstracts, keywords, and technical documentation aids researchers in understanding, locating, and reusing the objects, while addressing intellectual property rights and ensuring the legal status of the content is clearly outlined. This collaborative and structured ap-

proach underscores the complex, ongoing nature of curating and maintaining digital academic objects, ensuring they remain valuable and relevant in an evolving research landscape.

Continuous curation is essential as digital objects are modifiable and evolving (Kallinikos et al., 2010). This implies that curation must not only ensure the preservation of data but also keep it updated and accessible, adapting to new technological and methodological standards. As Borgman (2007) points out, curation of digital objects involves ongoing work to ensure that these objects remain relevant within the academic ecosystem. This adaptability is one of the features that distinguishes digital objects from traditional ones, as they can be reconfigured to address new research questions or be used in innovative methodological approaches.

The proposed guidelines, focused on evaluation, editing, and curation, has significant implications for knowledge building in the humanities. Digital objects, composed of structured data and semantic representations, enable a new epistemology that goes beyond traditional forms of academic publishing. Priani argues that digital data are not simply objective representations of reality, but constructions that depend on an interpretive framework. This epistemological fragility does not diminish the value of the data but highlights the need for a critical and reflective approach to how data are used and shared in research (Allés, 2019).

In conclusion, this proposal for the evaluation and editing of digital objects ensures they meet high technical and academic standards while recognizing their epistemological value. By integrating open science principles, innovative methodologies, and continuous curation, this proposal seeks to enhance the recognition of DH, enabling the creation of a more flexible, accessible, and dynamic academic communication system.